

EDM 101 – Ethics and Patients' Rights in Dental Medicine

Lecture 8

Business Ethics in Dentistry

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This classes learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you are able to

- Explain how business pressures influence ethical decision-making in dentistry.
- Identify unethical practices in advertising, treatment planning, and financial decisions.
- Apply ethical principles to conflicts between patient care and business interests.



Dentistry as a Profession and a Business

- Patients pay for treatment
- Dentists earn income
- Ethical duties must still be followed



Professional vs Business Ethics

Professional Ethics	Business Ethics
Patient-centered	Profit-driven
Focus on care	Focus on revenue
Ethical duty	Financial sustainability

Problems arise when business decisions override professional ethics



Importance of Legal Regulation

A conflict of interest occurs when:

- Personal or financial interests influence clinical decisions
- COI is not always unethical, but it creates risk

Having a conflict is normal – but acting unfairly because of it is unethical



Personal vs Patient Interest

Such as:

- A. Choosing faster but poorer treatment
- B. Scheduling based on convenience instead of quality
- C. Selecting profit over best care



Public vs Patient Interest

Dentists sometimes must balance:

- Individual patient needs
- Limited resources (time, cost, public systems)



Third-Party Influence

Third parties may influence decisions:

- A. Insurance companies
- B. Employers
- C. Government systems

The dentist must always recommend the best treatment for the patient, even if financial systems limit it.



Ethical Advertising

Advertising should:

- Be truthful
- Be evidence-based
- Provide information, not manipulation



Unethical Advertising

Unethical practices include:

- A. False claims
- B. Digitally enhanced results
- C. Claiming superiority over other dentists



Inducements and Discounts

Such as:

- A. Gifts for patients
- B. Referral rewards
- C. Heavy discounts

Problems related to these:

- Influences patient decisions unfairly



Social Media in Dentistry

Avoid:

- Misleading before and after images
- Creating unrealistic expectations
- Promoting unnecessary treatments



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Competitive Spirit vs Integrity

Competition may lead to:

1. Overtreatment
2. Undermining colleagues
3. Financial bias



Aesthetic and Cosmetic Dentistry

Esthetic Dentistry:

- Restores function and natural appearance

Cosmetic Dentistry:

- Changes appearance beyond normal



Ethical Issue in Cosmetic Dentistry

Problems include:

- A. Treating healthy teeth unnecessarily
- B. Following trends instead of science
- C. Patient pressure vs professional judgment



Extending Scope of Practice

Dentists must:

- Work within competence
- Avoid performing unfamiliar procedures
- Refer when needed



New / Unproven Treatments

Dentists must:

- Use evidence-based treatments
- Avoid promoting unproven techniques

Such as:

- Unnecessary frenectomy in infants



Unscientific Treatments:

Unethical examples:

- A. Rejecting proven treatments (fluoride, endodontics)
- B. Promoting fake or unsupported methods



Non-Dental Treatments:

Such as:

- Botox (outside proper indication)
- Fillers, tattoos, piercing

These may fall outside dentistry and can be unethical depending on context.



Unacceptable Business Practices:

- Overtreatment
- Undertreatment
- Charging for services not done
- Overcharging or undercharging
- Cutting corners



Summary:

- Dentistry is both business and profession
- Ethics must guide financial decisions
- Avoid conflicts of interest
- Use evidence-based practice
- Protect patient trust



Thank You!



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